Prospecting Guide

Building an account list from scratch

No contacts came with this package. Here's how to build a better list than one you could buy, in about two hours, for free.

Where the accounts come from

Google Maps and Google Business listings are the richest free source for local commercial buildings. Search a business type plus your area and you get name, address, phone, website, hours and review activity.

Two limits worth knowing: Google doesn't publish email addresses, so you'll get those from their website. And search results cap out, so search by suburb rather than by metro.

Other sources worth using:

- Commercial property listing sites — good for finding management companies and multi-tenant buildings
- Your county or city permit portal — new construction and fit-outs before anyone else notices
- Your state's business registry — new business filings, and officer names
- Local business journals — openings, moves, expansions
- Driving around — genuinely. New signage, fit-outs in progress, a building you pass every day

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Step 1 — Search

Pick one segment and one suburb at a time. Broad searches return the same big names everyone else is already calling.

Search terms that work, by segment:

Property management: property management company · commercial property management · real estate management **Office:** office building · law firm · accounting firm · insurance agency · financial advisor · title company · coworking **Medical:** dental office · medical clinic · urgent care · physical therapy · dermatology · veterinary clinic · outpatient **Industrial:** warehouse · distribution center · light manufacturing · fulfillment · self storage **Schools and childcare:** daycare · preschool · private school · learning center **Other:** gym · fitness center · church · community center

Expect 40–120 results per search in a decent-sized suburb. Put them straight into the Account Tracker.

Step 2 — Qualify

Apply these in order. The first filter removes the most, so it goes first.

#	Filter	Drop it when
1	**Real commercial premises**	Home-based, virtual office, PO box, or a listing with no fixed address
2	**Big enough**	Under roughly 1,500 sq ft — the contract won't justify the walkthrough
3	**Decided locally**	National chain or corporate campus where cleaning is contracted at head office
4	**Still trading**	No reviews or updates in twelve months
5	**Doesn't clean itself**	Restaurants and retail with closing staff who already do it
6	**Reachable**	No website *and* no phone
7	**You can service it**	Outside your radius, or needs something you don't do

Expect to keep about one in four or five. If you're keeping most of them, you're not being strict enough — and every account you keep is one you'll spend research time on.

Filter 3 is the one people get wrong

A chain restaurant, a bank branch, a national pharmacy: the manager is friendly, will take your call, and cannot buy anything. Cleaning is contracted centrally, often nationally. You can spend weeks on these. Check whether the brand has more than about ten locations; if so, assume it's central until someone tells you otherwise.

Step 3 — Estimate size and value

You need a rough monthly value to know whether an account is worth pursuing.

Estimating square footage without going there: commercial listing sites often publish it · county property records usually have it · or measure the footprint on a satellite map and multiply by floors. Rough is fine. Mark it as an estimate.

Then apply a rate. Rates vary widely by market, building type and frequency — use your own numbers from jobs you've actually priced. If you're new to commercial, price two or three walkthroughs before trusting any estimate.

The point isn't precision. It's separating a $300/month account from a $1,500/month one before you spend an hour on either.

Step 4 — Score

Five dimensions, 20 points. The tracker calculates the total.

Dimension	Points	What you're asking
Fit	0–5	Is this the kind of building I should pursue? 0 = disqualify

Dimension	Points	What you're asking
Value	0–5	Is it worth the effort if I win it?
Trigger	0–5	Is there a dated, public reason to contact them now?
Access	0–3	Can I reach someone who actually decides?
Service	0–2	Could I genuinely service it? 0 = disqualify

Bands: 16–20 work now · 12–15 work in order · 8–11 research or wait · below 8, stop.

Below 8 doesn't mean worthless. It means the effort costs more than it's likely to return, and your sending capacity is limited. Spend it on the top of the list.

Step 5 — Then find the trigger

Score everything else first, then hunt triggers only for the accounts that survived. Trigger hunting is the slowest step; doing it for accounts you can't service is wasted time.

Expect to find a real trigger on perhaps a third of your accounts. That's normal. The rest sit in your tracker until something changes — and because you're checking weekly, you'll be there when it does.

How many accounts do you need?

Fewer than you think, and better than you think.

Twenty well-qualified accounts with real triggers and named contacts will produce more than four hundred names from a bought list. You can research twenty properly. You cannot research four hundred, so you'd end up emailing all of them the same thing, which is what everyone else does.

Start with ten. Get through the whole loop once — find, qualify, score, trigger, contact, follow up. Then scale what worked.

Keeping the list clean

- **Check for duplicates** — the tracker flags repeated websites. Same company, two listings, is common.
- **Re-verify quarterly.** Businesses close, people leave, listings go stale.
- **Never re-add someone who opted out.** Keep one opt-out list and check it before every send.
- **Record where each account came from.** When one source produces better accounts than another, you'll only know if you wrote it down.